

Bastian Koch

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Research Interests

Corporate Finance, Entrepreneurship & Innovation, Labor & Finance

Education

University of Mannheim

Ph.D. in Finance

Supervisor: Prof. Ernst Maug, Ph.D.

Mannheim, Germany

Expected 2027

HEC Paris

Visiting Ph.D. Student

Host: Prof. Johan Hombert

Paris, France

March–May 2025

Peking University

Master of Finance

Beijing & Shenzhen, China

July 2020

Heinrich-Heine University

B.Sc. in Business Administration

Düsseldorf, Germany

July 2017

Working Papers

Tolerance for Failure: Evidence from Patent Examination (*with Minrui Gong*)

Abstract: We introduce a novel firm-level measure of failure tolerance based on firms' patenting histories. Specifically, we quantify failure tolerance as the worst patent examination outcome that is nevertheless followed by continued innovation along the same trajectory. Our results show that firms with greater failure tolerance tend to produce patents that are more valuable, more cited, more complex, yet also more likely to fail. At the same time, they file fewer patents and employ fewer inventors. Because higher quality comes at the expense of lower quantity, failure tolerance has little effect on firms' overall innovation output. Exploiting inventor job switches, we provide causal evidence that higher failure tolerance increases inventor productivity. Taken together, our findings establish failure tolerance as a powerful incentive mechanism while also highlighting its overlooked costs.

Pre-IPO Liquidity Events and Talent Allocation

Abstract: This paper studies how pre-IPO liquidity events affect employee retention, incentives, and talent allocation in high-growth startups. Using data on U.S. firms whose shares become tradable on private secondary-market platforms, matched with inventor-level patent information, I examine the impact of liquidity provision before an initial public offering. I find that pre-IPO liquidity does not increase overall employee turnover. High-performing employees with partially or fully vested options are more likely to stay, while lower-performing employees are more likely to leave following secondary-market listing. I find no evidence of reduced innovative productivity among remaining employees, while firms become more likely to attract high-quality talent. Overall, pre-IPO liquidity events facilitate human-capital reallocation without undermining innovative incentives.

Work in Progress

Board Connections and Inventor Productivity

Presentations & Workshops

2027: American Economic Association Annual Meeting (Lightning Round, forthcoming)

2026: Labor and Finance Group Spring Meeting, Vanderbilt University; Fourth BCFM PhD Conference, University of Cologne; World Finance Conference; 2nd HKU Next-Gen Finance PhD Workshop; Benelux Corporate Finance Days; German Finance Association Annual Meeting; GEABA Annual Conference, Mainz; Financial Management Association Annual Meeting; Southern Finance Association Annual Meeting

2025: Summer PhD Workshop on Entrepreneurial Finance

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant for Corporate Finance I and II Graduate, University of Mannheim	2022–present
Teaching Assistant for Stata in Finance Graduate, University of Mannheim	2022–present
Teaching Assistant for Corporate Finance and Risk Management Undergraduate, University of Mannheim	2024–2025
Thesis Supervisor Bachelor and Master, University of Mannheim (4 bachelor's and 10 master's theses)	2022–present

Scholarships & Grants

EFA Travel Grant European Finance Association	2025
GESS Scholarship Graduate School of Economic and Social Sciences, University of Mannheim	2021
Full Tuition Scholarship Peking University	2018–2020
German National Scholarship (Deutschlandstipendium) Heinrich-Heine University Düsseldorf	2015–2017
High Potential Mobility Grant Heinrich-Heine University Düsseldorf	2016

Skills

Software: Python, R, Stata, L^AT_EX (advanced); Julia (intermediate)

Languages: German (native); English (fluent); Chinese (intermediate); French (beginner)

References

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